

Consumer Attitudes toward Sponsors' Counterambush Marketing Ads

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ABSTRACT

Since the existing measures to prevent ambush marketing are widely ineffective, sponsors can use countercommunications, a public response to an ambushing attempt that aims to strengthen their own brand, relative to the ambusher. This research examines consumer responses to three types of counterambush marketing ads: humorous complaining, naming and shaming, and consumer education. Three experimental studies using both real and fictitious brands as well as different event settings indicate that a humorous counterad (vs. naming and shaming and consumer education counterads) results in more favorable consumer evaluations of the countermesssage. The studies also show that perceptions of the advertising tactic's appropriateness mediate these effects and that a humorous counterad is only advantageous when consumers hold positive (vs. negative) attitudes toward the practice of ambush marketing. In addition, comparing the three types of counterads with a common sponsorship leveraging ad suggests that a humorous counterad and simply ignoring the ambusher produce equal perceptions of tactical appropriateness and similar positive indirect effects on consumer attitudes toward the ad. The studies thus provide implications for how sponsors can respond to ambushers. © 2017 Wiley Periodicals, Inc.

Sponsorship has been in a state of constant expansion over the past decades (IEG, 2015), and as sponsorship has grown, so too has the practice of ambush marketing. The term ambush marketing is commonly used to describe activities of nonsponsors that aim to generate the positive effects of sponsorship without an official affiliation with the sponsored property (i.e., without possessing sponsorship rights; Chadwick & Burton, 2011). Ambush marketing is used most often (and commented by the media) around major events, such as Olympic Games and World Championships (Payne, 1998).

Both sponsorship rights holders and sponsors are eager to find ways to make the opportunity to exploit the commercial potential associated with sponsored properties as exclusive to the sponsors as possible. To this end, several counterambushing strategies (e.g., the continual expansion of rights holder sponsorship programs, legislation, on-site and media policing) that aim to prevent or limit ambushing opportunities have been implemented over the past years to protect the rights of official sponsors. Although these counterstrategies pose some restrictions on nonsponsor activities, several loopholes and many opportunities for ambushing still exist beyond the reach of these measures. It seems, therefore, that the prevention of ambush marketing is an unrealistic goal, and rights holders and sponsors have to

accept the fact that ambushing is part of major events and has to be dealt with in some way (Farrelly, Quester, & Greyser, 2005; McKelvey & Grady, 2008). While previous research has focused on prevention and looked at the possibilities that rights holders have to ensure exclusivity to sponsors (Crompton, 2004; Scassa, 2011), this research focuses on reaction and looks into how sponsors may respond to ambush marketing.

So what are the goals of sponsors with respect to ambushing, and what can they do about it? Sponsors' responses to ambushing attempts focus on reinforcing their status as being officially associated with the sponsored property and strengthening their brand in relation to the ambushing brand (Humphreys et al., 2010). One central tool to achieve this is counterambush marketing communications, that is, a public response to ambushing that aims to enhance the own brand and (directly or indirectly) denounce the ambushing brand. However, to date, no research has examined how consumers perceive and respond to different types of counterambushing communications.

To address this gap, this research examines three types of counterambush marketing ads and compares their effects on consumer responses: humorous counterads versus name and shame counterads (Studies 1, 2, and 3) versus educational counterads (Studies 2

and 3). In doing so, this research makes the following contributions. First, the study compares the effects of different types of counterambush marketing ads (vs. common sponsorship leveraging; Study 3). While previous research shows that a third-party disclosure of an ambusher (i.e., the media) can decrease consumer attitudes toward the ambushing brand (Mazodier, Quester, & Chandon, 2012), no study has examined a situation where the official sponsor is the source of countercommunications and how consumers respond to these countermessages. This is important because sponsors may not be willing to leave it to the media or the sponsored property to decide whether and how to respond to an ambushing attempt.

Second, in the comparison of the three types of counterads, this research considers response variables relating to both the advertising tactic (i.e., perceived tactical appropriateness) and the ad itself (i.e., attitude toward the ad). Thus, the studies provide insights into how the different types of counterads influence consumers' responses. Further, the present research takes into account consumer attitudes toward the practice of ambush marketing—a variable that has been shown to vary across consumers in descriptive studies (Dickson, Naylor, & Phelps, 2015)—as a boundary condition.

The remainder of this article is structured as follows: The next section presents the conceptual background for ambush marketing and counterambush marketing communications from the sponsors' perspective. Next, hypotheses are developed for differences in the effects between humorous counterads and name and shame counterads and the results of a first empirical study are presented. The subsequent section extends the theoretical arguments to educational counterads and presents the results of a second empirical study. The third study includes another condition, namely sponsorship leveraging, and leads to the conclusions.

CONCEPTUAL BACKGROUND AND HYPOTHESES

The Nature of Ambush Marketing

A common characteristic of ambushing activities is the attempt to benefit from a property in a way that is not legitimized by a sponsorship contract. Despite this commonality, ambush marketing is not a discrete entity but the term embraces a plethora of activities and different classifications of these activities have been suggested (Chadwick & Burton, 2011; Crompton, 2004; Meenaghan, 1996). For example, ambushing activities include the purchase of advertising time within event broadcasts, use of imagery in advertisements that imply an association with the property, or excessive activation of a lower category sponsorship to gain similar benefits as a major sponsor (Chadwick & Burton, 2011; Meenaghan, 1994, 1996).

Due to the diverse nature of ambush marketing, a generalizable assessment of its legal and ethical status is hardly possible (Meenaghan, 1994; O'Sullivan & Murphy, 1998). Most ambushing activities are not illegal because they do not violate laws, such as trademark of unfair competition laws (Burton & Chadwick, 2009; Scassa, 2011). Even with special antiambush marketing legislation, which has recently been introduced in countries that host major sport events to extend the rights of sponsors by prohibiting any kind of unauthorized association with the sponsorship property, the legal basis to combat ambushing is limited (Scassa, 2011). Ethical judgments made (outside courtyards) by official sponsors and rights holders tend to be driven by self-interest. They argue that ambush marketing is unethical because it is misleading, false, and unfair (Meenaghan, 1994; Payne, 1998). On the other hand, some scholars and commentators view ambushing as a legitimate and clever marketing practice that is not unethical *per se* (Meenaghan, 1996). Therefore, a more balanced approach to address ambush marketing has been called for that takes into consideration the interests of all parties, including rights holders and sponsors as well as the general public, consumers, and nonsponsors (Scassa, 2011). Since consumers too vary in their opinions about ambush marketing and do not generally judge this practice as unethical (Dickson et al., 2015; Lyberger & McCarthy, 2001; Shani & Sandler, 1998), this research takes into account consumers' attitudes toward ambushing activities.

The wide range of ambushing activities and tactics also pose issues for rights holders and sponsors regarding an appropriate counterstrategy. Legal action is widely ineffective or even counterproductive when these actions provide additional publicity to the ambusher (Burton & Chadwick, 2009). Other counterambush marketing tools aim to protect the rights of official sponsors by proactively limiting ambushing opportunities around event venues and in the media. For example, rights holders declare clean zones around venues or clean transport routes leading to venues, where unauthorized commercial activities are prohibited. Extensive on-site policing helps enforce clean zones. In addition, sponsorship contracts often guarantee official sponsors a preemptive right to purchase advertising space around event venues and advertising time within event broadcasts. Preevent education and public relations initiatives are another approach to respond to (potential) ambushing activities (McKelvey & Grady, 2008). This strategy seeks to develop an understanding of the differences between official sponsorship and ambush marketing among consumers and companies. While both rights holders and sponsors can engage in antiambushing activities, rights holders play a dominant role in implementing the approaches summarized above.

This research focuses on counterambush marketing communications that originates from the official sponsor. Antiambush marketing communications is an original task for sponsors because the competitive

relationships with other brands (ambushers) usually continue beyond a single event and the official sponsor–ambusher situation. Most sponsors have good knowledge about general communication activities of their competitors and the general competitive sphere in their market (McGee & Rubach, 1997). Thus, they are in a good position to evaluate what an appropriate (and favorable) response may be. Furthermore, sponsors are interested in having full control over countercommunications. Since some rights holders (e.g., sport organizations hosting major events) are subject to criticism (e.g., corruption; Kulczycki & Koenigstorfer, 2016), rights holders' countercommunications may lack authenticity and may thus be perceived as noncredible. This is another reason why countercommunications from the sponsors' perspective is managerially relevant.

Counterambush Marketing Communications

Counterambush marketing communications originating from the official sponsor is a response of the sponsor brand to the ambushing activities of another brand (Humphreys et al., 2010). Such responsive communications do not aim to prevent or limit ambushing opportunities. Instead, sponsors use countercommunications to achieve their objectives by strengthening their own brand and weakening the ambushing brand. This research uses the term counterambush marketing communications to describe any communication that refers to either a specific ambushing attempt or the issue of ambush marketing, generally, in order to reinforce the official sponsorship status of the sponsor brand and directly or indirectly denounce the ambusher. A key goal of counterambush marketing communications is to signal the official sponsor's superior status (compared to the ambusher) by informing the recipients that only the sponsor is legitimately associated with the property.

The way in which this information is passed on, that is, the specific content and framing of countercommunications, is subject to variation. First, countermessages can severely and straightforwardly derogate the ambusher by portraying the brand as a marketing fraud, a tactic that is referred to as the “name and shame” approach (Burton & Chadwick, 2009). Second, countermessages can focus on increasing liking of the sponsor brand by denigrating the ambusher in a humorous and poised way, a strategy that parallels the concept of “humorous complaining” (McGraw, Warren, & Kan, 2015). Another option is that the sponsor denounces the ambusher indirectly by publishing an educational ad that informs the public about the potentially negative consequences of ambush marketing without a direct reference to a particular brand (McKelvey & Grady, 2008). Thus, “consumer education” is a third approach to countercommunications.

Although many different approaches are conceivable, only the name and shame tactic has been subject to academic inquiry. Name and shame

countermessages directly attack the ambusher and aim to correct the potential misbelief that the ambushing brand is officially associated with the sponsored property. Empirical evidence indicates that naming and shaming the ambusher can negatively affect consumer attitudes toward the ambushing brand (Mazodier & Quester, 2010; Mazodier et al., 2012). However, these studies considered ambush-marketing disclosure that originated from a third party (i.e., the media), and the studies did not look at recipients' evaluation of countermessages. The present research considers name and shame countermessages that originate from sponsor brands and focuses on how these messages influence consumer attitudes toward the countermessage. This seems necessary because the message content itself is central to consumers' processing of any countercommunications (Jain, 1993). The next section contrasts name and shame counterads with humorous counterads and develops arguments about how these countercommunications messages influence consumer attitudes toward the ad.

Consumer Responses to Name and Shame Counterads versus Humorous Counterads

Cornwell, Weeks, and Roy (2005, p. 35) note that “since most of the ambushing tactics are whimsical or fun, few, except the true sponsors, are likely to hold negative opinions of the ambusher.” In a response to this claim, Humphreys et al. (2010) suggest that sponsors might benefit from a more positive communications approach because consumers often like the creativity and wit of ambushing attempts and may perceive a blunt attack on the ambusher as inappropriate. Against this backdrop, this research examines consumer responses to humorous counterads, in comparison to name and shame counterads. A key consumer response to advertising in general and, in particular, in situations where brands make references to another brand is the perceived appropriateness of an advertising tactic (Barone & Jewell, 2012; Friestad & Wright, 1994). Drawing on arguments from three streams of research—comparative advertising (Jain, 1993; Jain & Posavac, 2004), humor in advertising (Ferguson & Ford, 2008; Ford & Ferguson, 2004), and humorous complaining (McGraw et al., 2015), the present research proposes that consumers perceive humorous (vs. name and shame) countercommunications as a more appropriate advertising tactic.

Name and shame counterads have a mean-spirited nature as they contain a straightforward denouncement of the ambusher. Thus, consumers' perception that the message content is inappropriate should be higher when sponsors use name and shame (vs. humorous) counterads because the former type of counterad is a blatant attempt to decry the ambusher in the interest of their own brand (Jain & Posavac, 2004). This is particularly true when name and shame counterads are compared to humorous counterads because the type of humor used in counterads can be classified

as disparagement humor, a form of humor that elicits “amusement through the denigration, derogation, or belittlement of a given target” (Ferguson & Ford, 2008, p. 283). Disparagement humor increases people’s tolerance and acceptance of denouncing the disparaged group (or brand) and activates a mindset that makes people less critical of discriminatory events, that is, it “expands the bounds of appropriate conduct, creating a norm of tolerance of discrimination” (Ford & Ferguson, 2004, p. 79). Thus, consumers’ judgments that denigrating the ambushing brand is inappropriate, unfair, or unethical should be lower when the denigration happens humorously. Furthermore, McGraw et al. (2015) find empirical evidence that humorously critiquing someone (vs. a nonhumorous critique) increases liking of both the complaint and the complainer.

Taken together, the aforementioned arguments suggest that counterambushing ads are perceived as a more appropriate advertising tactic when the ambusher is denigrated humorously, as compared to naming and shaming the ambusher. As part of consumers’ persuasion knowledge, the perceived appropriateness of an advertising tactic is an important precursor of attitudinal variables (Barone & Jewell, 2012; Friestad & Wright, 1994; Shiv, Edell, & Payne, 1997). Thus, it is expected that counterads exert an indirect effect on consumers’ overall attitudes toward the ad through the perceived appropriateness of the advertising tactic.

H1: A humorous counterambushing ad will be perceived as a more appropriate advertising tactic than a name and shame counterambushing ad.

H2: Perceptions of the advertising tactic’s appropriateness will mediate a positive effect of a humorous counterambushing ad (vs. a name and shame counterambushing ad) on attitude toward the ad.

The Moderating Role of Attitudes toward Ambush Marketing

Consumer attitudes toward ambush marketing vary greatly, ranging from acceptance, to apathy, to refusal (Dickson et al., 2015). This study proposes that more favorable responses to humorous counterads relative to the name and shame approach only occur when consumers hold positive attitudes toward ambush marketing, whereas the differences should disappear when consumer attitudes are negative. Generally, a person’s tolerance of disparaging others increases with his or her level of prejudice toward the disparaged other and what he or she is doing (Ford & Ferguson, 2004). Thus, consumers who hold negative opinions about ambush marketing are more likely to consider the naming and shaming of the ambusher as justified and should not perceive this blatant derogation as overly inappropriate. In addition, benign violation theory proposes that a humorous complaint (vs. a nonhumorous complaint)

indicates that the cause for the complaint is in some way not serious or harmless (McGraw & Warren, 2010; McGraw, Schwartz, & Tetlock, 2012). Thus, the playful character of a humorous counterad is likely to suggest to the consumers that the behavior of the ambusher is not overly threatening. An ad expressing this relatively lenient evaluation of ambushing is more consistent with those consumers who hold positive opinions about ambush marketing, whereas it is inconsistent with the attitudes of consumers that reject the practice. In sum, a humorous countermessage will likely only be perceived as a more appropriate advertising tactic than naming and shaming the ambusher when consumers hold positive attitudes toward the practice of ambushing. The proposed moderating effect on perceived tactical appropriateness implies that the indirect effect of humorous (vs. name and shame) counterads on attitudes toward the ad will depend on attitude toward ambush marketing, too. The third hypothesis is thus stated as follows:

H3a: A humorous counterambushing ad (vs. a name and shame counterambushing ad) will be perceived as a more appropriate advertising tactic by consumers with a positive (but not with a negative) attitude toward ambush marketing.

H3b: The positive indirect effect of a humorous counterambushing ad (vs. a name and shame counterambushing ad) on attitude toward the ad will only occur when consumers hold a positive (but not a negative) attitude toward ambush marketing.

STUDY 1

To test H1, H2, and H3, Study 1 compares recipients’ responses to two different counterambush marketing ads—humorous counterads and name and shame counterads—depending on their attitudes toward the practice of ambush marketing.

Method

Participants. One hundred and seven students (40 women; age: $M = 22.5$ years, standard deviation [SD] = 2.4) completed the study after they had given their informed consent for participation.

Design, Procedure, and Measures. The study applied a between-participant design, manipulating the counterambush marketing strategy used by the sponsor (humorous counterad, $n = 56$ vs. name and shame counterad, $n = 51$). Participants were randomly assigned to one of the two experimental conditions. The moderator attitude toward ambush marketing was measured.

Table 1. Regression Results for Predictors of Perceived Tactical Appropriateness of the Sponsor's Counterstrategy for Study 1 (Two Ads), Study 2 (Three Ads), and Study 3 (Four Ads).

Predictors	Study 1 (<i>N</i> = 107)			Study 2 (<i>N</i> = 162)			Study 3 (<i>N</i> = 126)		
	Perceived Tactical Appropriateness			Perceived Tactical Appropriateness			Perceived Tactical Appropriateness		
	<i>b</i>	SE	<i>p</i>	<i>b</i>	SE	<i>p</i>	<i>b</i>	SE	<i>p</i>
Name and shame (dummy 1)	−0.69	0.21	0.001	−0.13	0.24	0.59	−0.53	0.29	0.07
Consumer education (dummy 2)	–	–	–	0.72	0.24	0.003	−0.11	0.30	0.71
Leveraging (dummy 3)	–	–	–	–	–	–	0.29	0.30	0.34
Attitude ambush marketing	−0.11	0.15	0.47	0.01	0.17	0.98	−0.14	0.22	0.52
Name and shame (dummy 1) × attitude ambush marketing	−0.41	0.20	<0.05	−0.57	0.24	0.02	−0.32	0.32	0.31
Consumer education (dummy 2) × attitude ambush marketing	–	–	–	−0.49	0.23	0.03	−0.65	0.32	<0.05
Leveraging (dummy 3) × attitude ambush marketing	–	–	–	–	–	–	−0.10	0.33	0.76

Participants were told that the study was about sport sponsorship. They were first shown an advertisement of the ambusher (here: Durex [a condom manufacturer] ambushing a fictitious golf event) and answered some distraction questions about the advertisement. Next, they were told that the official sponsor of the event (here: Billy Boy [another condom manufacturer]) responded to Durex' ambush marketing campaign with its own advertisement. Depending on the experimental condition, participants were shown either the humorous counterad or the name and shame counterad. All ads were self-designed, using Adobe Photoshop software (Appendix 1). Participants then filled in some standardized items, including the manipulation check and the dependent variables of interest. Attitude toward ambush marketing was assessed at the end of the study. Measures are shown in Appendix 2. Finally, after completing a hypothesis guessing-task, participants were fully debriefed.

Results and Discussion

The manipulation was successful (Appendix 3). To test the hypotheses, a moderated regression analysis was conducted using perceived tactical appropriateness of the sponsor's counterambush marketing strategy as the dependent variable. As independent variables, the analysis included a dummy that represented the type of counterad (coding: 1 = name and shame counterad, 0 = humorous counterad), mean-centered attitude toward ambush marketing, and the interaction of attitude toward ambush marketing and the dummy (model $R^2 = 0.22$). Table 1 (left column) shows the results of the analysis.

The hypothesized interaction of type of counterad and attitude toward ambush marketing was significant ($b = -0.41$, $SE = 0.20$, $p < 0.05$). Name and shame (vs. humorous advertising) had a negative effect ($b = -0.69$,

$SE = 0.21$, $p = 0.001$), and attitude toward ambush marketing (representing the slope in the humor condition) was unrelated to the perceived tactical appropriateness of the sponsor's counterambush marketing strategy ($b = -0.11$, $SE = 0.15$, $p = 0.47$). The slope was negative in the humorous advertising condition ($b = -0.52$, $SE = 0.14$, $p < 0.001$). To find out at which levels of attitude toward ambush marketing participants perceived the ad significantly more appropriate in the humorous advertising condition (vs. the name and shame condition), a floodlight analysis using the Johnson–Neyman procedure was conducted (Spiller, Fitzsimons, Lynch, & McClelland, 2013). The analysis showed that, at a level of 2.40 in attitude toward ambush marketing (i.e., 0.53 SDs below the mean), the simple main effect of the countercommunications strategy was significant. Thus, the humorous counterad resulted in higher perceptions of tactical appropriateness at mean and positive levels of attitude toward ambush marketing. The effect was significant at 0.53 SDs below the mean and higher. For all levels of attitude lower than 0.53 SDs below the mean, which represent rather negative attitudes, the effect was nonsignificant. The range of significance is displayed in gray color in Figure 1.

A moderated mediation analysis assessed the impact of the independent variables (including perceived tactical appropriateness of the sponsor's counterstrategy) on attitude toward the ad (model $R^2 = 0.52$). The direct effect of perceived tactical appropriateness was significant ($b = 0.67$, $SE = 0.12$, $p < 0.001$). The direct effect of name and shame (vs. humorous advertising) was also significant ($b = -1.41$, $SE = 0.27$, $p < 0.001$), and attitude toward ambush marketing was negatively related with attitude toward the ad ($b = -0.51$, $SE = 0.18$, $p < 0.01$). The interaction of humorous advertising and attitude toward ambush marketing was marginally significant ($b = 0.46$, $SE = 0.25$, $p = 0.07$). Follow-up analyses revealed that the conditional indirect effect of name and shame (vs. humorous advertising) was

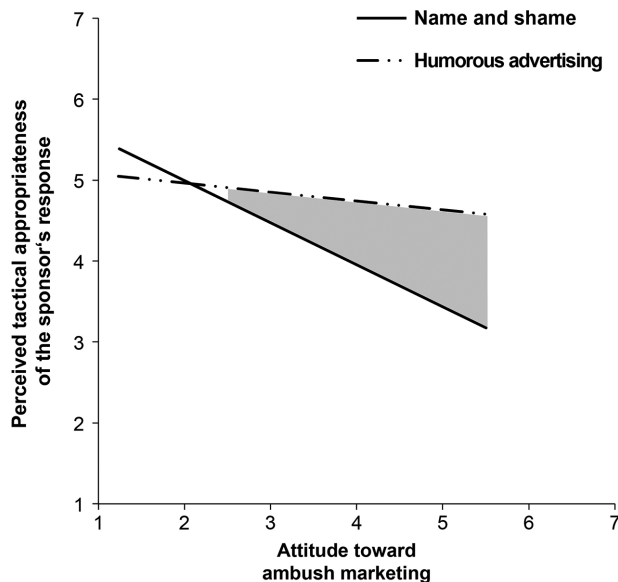


Figure 1. The relationship between recipients' attitudes toward ambush marketing and perceived tactical appropriateness of the sponsor's counterstrategy, depending on the experimental condition in Study 1 (humorous advertising vs. name and shame).

nonsignificant at low levels of attitude toward ambush marketing (i.e., at one SD [$SD = 1.04$] below the mean [$M = 2.94$] of attitude toward ambush marketing, $b = -0.18$, with a bootstrap confidence interval ranging from -0.61 to 0.22 , based on 5000 bootstrap samples). At mid and high levels of attitude toward ambush marketing, however, the conditional indirect effect of humorous advertising was positive (i.e., at the mean: $b = -0.47$, with a bootstrap confidence interval ranging from -0.82 to -0.20 ; at one SD above the mean: $b = -0.75$, with a bootstrap confidence interval ranging from -1.31 to -0.34). A negative and significant index of moderated mediation ($b = -0.28$, with a bootstrap confidence interval ranging from -0.63 to -0.01) supports the hypothesis that the indirect effect of humorous advertising on attitude toward the ad via perceived tactical appropriateness is dependent on attitude toward ambush marketing.

Study 1 revealed a positive effect of humorous advertising (vs. name and shame) in the sense that increased perceptions of appropriateness of the advertising tactic mediated the positive effects on attitude toward the ad at high levels (but not at low levels) of consumer attitude toward ambush marketing. There was a positive direct effect of humorous advertising on attitude toward the ad. One limitation of Study 1 is that it looked at only two types of counterads. Study 2 will thus include educational counterads as another strategy to counter an ambushing attempt. In addition, Study 1 can be criticized in terms of its generalizability because only one sport event context (i.e., a golf tournament) and one product category for the ambusher and the sponsor (i.e., real-brand condom manufacturers) were used. Study 2

was designed to address these limitations by using a different event context and another product category as well as fictitious brands.

EDUCATIONAL COUNTERADS

Besides naming and shaming and humorous counter-messages, educational counter-messages are another approach that sponsors can use to respond to an ambushing attempt. Educational counter-messages inform consumers about the negative consequences that ambush marketing may have for the sponsored property (McKelvey & Grady, 2008; Townley, Harrington, & Couchman, 1998). Educational counter-messages do not directly refer to a particular ambusher. However, in response to an ambushing attempt, this type of counter-message makes the reference to the ambushing brand by clear implication. While the strategy is an indirect and more subtle approach, its primary goal is similar to the name and shame approach because educational counter-messages aim to convince consumers that ambushing is an unacceptable form of marketing communications.

One key question related to the processing of this type of countermessage is whether consumers perceive the indirect derogation of the ambushing brand as a more appropriate advertising tactic, compared to the direct and straightforward derogation of the naming and shaming approach. The findings of previous studies on comparative advertising point out that there are no differences between direct and indirect comparative ads in terms of ad liking, ad believability (Pechmann & Ratneshwar, 1991), perceived reliability and helpfulness of the ad claims (McDougall, 1978), counter-argumentation, and advertiser attributions (Jain & Posavac, 2004). Therefore, it is expected that the humor versus education comparison will result in similar findings as the humor versus name and shame comparison.

STUDY 2

Study 2 compares recipients' response to counterambush marketing ads that use humor, the name and shame approach, or educational content. Another goal of Study 2 was to replicate the findings from Study 1, using fictitious brands, a different product category, and a different sport event context.

Method

Participants. One hundred and sixty-two students (76 women; age: $M = 24.2$ years, $SD = 2.9$) completed the study after they had given their informed consent for participation.

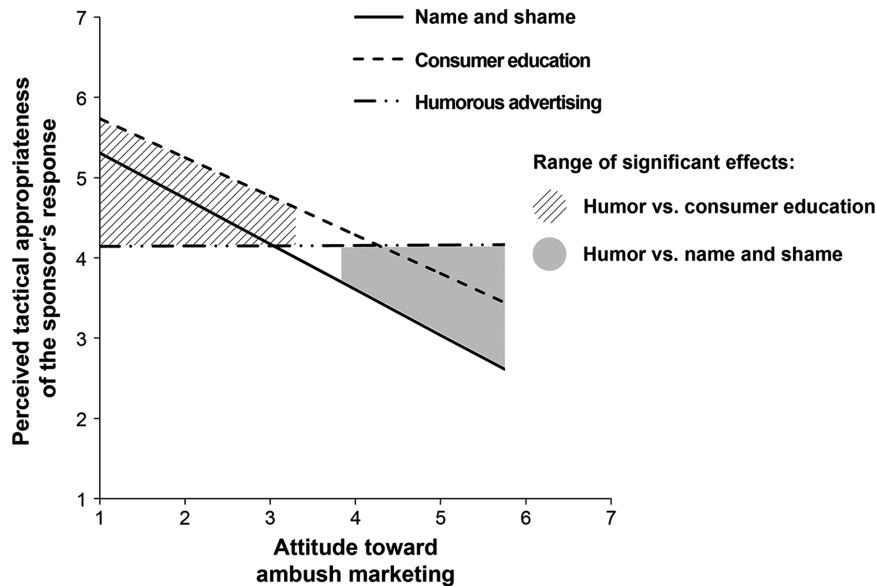


Figure 2. The relationship between recipients' attitudes toward ambush marketing and perceived tactical appropriateness of the sponsor's counterstrategy, depending on the experimental condition in Study 2 (humorous advertising vs. name and shame vs. consumer education).

Design, Procedure, and Measures. The study applied a between-participant design, manipulating the counterambushing strategy used by the sponsor (humorous counterad vs. name and shame counterad vs. educational counterad; $n = 54$ each). The procedure was identical to Study 1. Study 2 used fictitious sports drink producers as the ambushing brand (NRG) and the sponsor brand (BOOST). An international diving contest served as the background for the study. The ambushing ad and the three versions of the sponsor's counterad (all self-designed) are shown in Appendix 1 and measures are shown in Appendix 2.

Results and Discussion

The manipulation was successful (for details see Appendix 3). A moderated regression analysis for perceived tactical appropriateness of the sponsor's counterambushing strategy as the dependent variable tested the hypotheses. As independent variables, the analysis included two dummy variables to represent the differences between the three conditions (coding: dummy 1: name and shame = 1, all other conditions = 0; dummy 2: education = 1, all other conditions = 0), mean-centered attitude toward ambush marketing, and the interactions of attitude toward ambush marketing with the two dummy variables.

Table 1 (middle column) provides an overview of the results (model $R^2 = 0.19$). The hypothesized interaction of name and shame (dummy 1) and attitude toward ambush marketing (which represents the difference in the slope of attitude toward ambush marketing between the name and shame and the humorous counterad) was significant ($b = -0.57$, $SE = 0.24$, $p = 0.02$).

The interaction of consumer education (dummy 2) and attitude toward ambush marketing (which represents the difference in the slope of attitude toward ambush marketing between the educational and the humorous counterad) was also significant ($b = -0.49$, $SE = 0.23$, $p = 0.03$). The difference in the slopes of attitude toward ambush marketing between the name and shame and the educational counterads was not significant ($b = -0.09$, $SE = 0.22$, $p = 0.69$). The simple slopes of attitude toward ambush marketing in each of the three conditions were as follows: name and shame condition: $b = -0.57$, $SE = 0.16$, $p < 0.001$; consumer education condition: $b = -0.48$, $SE = 0.14$, $p < 0.001$; and humorous advertising condition: $b = 0.01$, $SE = 0.17$, $p = 0.98$. The results thus support the hypotheses. The slope of attitude toward ambush marketing is negative in both the name and shame and the educational counterad conditions, but the negative slope disappears in the humorous counterad condition.

Figure 2 displays the ratings of the appropriateness of the sponsor's counterad, as perceived by the three experimental groups, depending on the level of attitude toward ambush marketing (using nonmean-centered scores of attitude toward ambush marketing across the range of values actually observed in the sample). A floodlight analysis showed that at scores for attitude toward ambush marketing of 3.78 and higher (3.29 and lower), that is, 0.86 SDs above the mean and higher (0.40 SDs above the mean and lower), the simple main effect of the type of counterad—humor versus name and shame (humor vs. consumer education)—was significant.

A moderated mediation analysis was conducted to test whether perceived tactical appropriateness of the sponsor's counterstrategy mediates the effects of

the different counterads on attitude toward the ad (depending on attitude toward ambush marketing). The analysis models perceived tactical appropriateness of the sponsor's counterstrategy as a function of type of counterad (using two dummy variables as described earlier), mean-centered attitude toward ambush marketing, and the interactions of attitude toward ambush marketing and the two dummy variables. In the analysis, attitude toward the ad depends on the same five variables plus perceived tactical appropriateness of the sponsor's counterstrategy.

The regression results for perceived tactical appropriateness of the sponsor's counterstrategy are the same as those reported in Table 1. The effect of perceived tactical appropriateness on attitude toward the ad (model $R^2 = 0.40$) was positive ($b = 0.65$, $SE = 0.09$, $p < 0.001$). The direct effects of both the name and shame (dummy 1; $b = -1.58$, $SE = 0.28$, $p < 0.001$) and the educational counterad (dummy 2; $b = -1.89$, $SE = 0.25$, $p < 0.001$) on attitude toward the ad were negative, but both interactions (dummy 1 $\times$ attitude toward ambush marketing $b = 0.29$, $SE = 0.26$, $p = 0.26$; dummy 2 $\times$ attitude toward ambush marketing $b = 0.07$, $SE = 0.20$, $p = 0.72$) were nonsignificant. Also, attitude toward ambush marketing was unrelated with attitude toward the ad ($b = -0.19$, $SE = 0.14$, $p = 0.19$).

Follow-up analyses using a coding, where the humorous counterad was coded 1 and the other conditions were coded 0, indicated that the indirect effect of the type of counterad was nonsignificant at low levels of attitude toward ambush marketing (i.e., at one SD [$SD = 1.09$] below the mean [$M = 2.86$]: $b = -0.32$, with a bootstrap confidence interval ranging from -0.90 to 0.18 , based on 5000 bootstrap samples). However, at high levels of attitude toward ambush marketing, the indirect effect of the humorous counterad was positive (i.e., at one SD above the mean: $b = 0.49$, with a bootstrap confidence interval ranging from 0.05 to 1.02). A positive and significant index of moderated mediation ($b = 0.37$, with a bootstrap confidence interval ranging from 0.04 to 0.78) shows that the indirect effect of the type of counterad on attitude toward the ad is dependent on attitude toward ambush marketing. The results thus support the hypotheses because perceived tactical appropriateness mediated the effect of humorous advertising (vs. name and shame and consumer education) on attitude toward the ad at high levels (but not at low levels) of recipients' attitude toward ambush-marketing practices.

Study 2 showed that perceptions of tactical appropriateness decreased when consumers had positive attitudes toward ambush marketing in the name and shame condition but not in the humorous advertising condition. In the consumer education condition, perceptions of tactical appropriateness decreased when consumers had positive attitudes toward ambush marketing analogously to the name and shame condition. As hypothesized, humorous counterads (vs. both other

types of countercommunications) influenced attitude toward the ad indirectly and positively at high levels (but not at low levels) of attitude toward ambush marketing. Also, humorous advertising as a counterambush marketing strategy, compared to the name and shame and consumer education approaches, had a positive direct effect on attitude toward the ad. In sum, the findings of Studies 1 and 2 indicate that humorous counterads produce more favorable attitudes toward the ad than both the name and shame approach and educational counterads.

The findings of Studies 1 and 2 provide insights into how consumers respond to different types of counterambushing ads. While these findings assist sponsors willing to countercommunicate in deciding which strategy to use, the studies are silent on the question of whether or not countercommunications should be used at all. Thus, an important question related to Studies 1 and 2 is: How do consumers perceive the tactical appropriateness of counterads in comparison with a sponsorship leveraging campaign in response to an ambushing attempt?

SPONSORSHIP LEVERAGING

Sponsorship leveraging refers to the use of promotional activities related to a sponsorship that aim to strengthen the association between the sponsor and the sponsored property (Cornwell et al., 2005). Several authors suggest that sponsorship leveraging is an effective countermeasure because it minimizes the potential impact of ambush marketing (Crompton, 2004; Shani & Sandler, 1998; Séguin, Lyberger, O'Reilly, & McCarthy, 2005). The main characteristic that distinguishes a sponsorship leveraging ad from counterambushing ads is that no direct or indirect reference is made to the ambushing brand. Leveraging ads reinforce the official sponsorship status of the sponsor without derogating the ambusher.

Tentative predictions, with respect to potential differences between leveraging ads and counterads, in terms of consumers' perceptions of tactical appropriateness and ad attitude, can be made based on research that looks at comparative versus noncomparative advertising. Since comparative (vs. noncomparative) ads are cognitively demanding (Grewal, Kavanoor, Fern, Costley, & Barnes, 1997), they should result in lower believability and higher perceptions of unfairness, in particular when the benefits of the ad are uncertain (Jain, Buchanan, & Maheswaran, 2000). Thus, counterads in comparison with a leveraging ad should result in lower perceptions of tactical appropriateness (and attitude toward the ad in turn). As humorous countercommunications is entertaining and amusing (and thus, beneficial) for consumers, the differences in perceived tactical appropriateness should not occur between a humorous counterad and a leveraging ad.

STUDY 3

The goals of Study 3 were to compare recipients' response to counterambushing ads with response to a sponsorship leveraging ad and to replicate the findings of Studies 1 and 2.

Method

Participants. One hundred and twenty-six students (53 women; age: $M = 22.0$ years, $SD = 2.1$) completed the study after they had given their informed consent for participation.

Design, Procedure, and Measures. The study applied a between-participant design, manipulating the response of the sponsor to an ambushing attempt (humorous counterad, $n = 32$ vs. name and shame counterad, $n = 34$ vs. educational counterad, $n = 30$ vs. leveraging ad, $n = 30$). The procedure was identical to Studies 1 and 2. The same advertisements as in Study 1 were used for the ambushing ad, humorous counterad, and name and shame counterad. Two additional ads were created for the educational counterad condition and the leveraging-ad condition (Appendix 1). Measures are presented in Appendix 2.

Results

The manipulation was successful (Appendix 3). A moderated regression analysis for perceived tactical appropriateness of the sponsor's response as the dependent variable tested the hypotheses. As independent variables, the analysis included three dummy variables to represent the differences between the four conditions (coding: dummy 1: name and shame = 1, all other conditions = 0; dummy 2: education = 1, all other conditions = 0; dummy 3: leveraging = 1, all other conditions = 0), mean-centered attitude toward ambush marketing, and the interactions of attitude toward ambush marketing with the three dummy variables.

Table 1 (right column) provides an overview of the results (model $R^2 = 0.18$). The interaction of consumer education (dummy 2) and attitude toward ambush marketing was significant ($b = -0.65$, $SE = 0.32$, $p < 0.05$), whereas the interaction of name and shame (dummy 1) and attitude toward ambush marketing was not significant ($b = -0.32$, $SE = 0.32$, $p = 0.31$). Also, the interaction of leveraging (dummy 3) and attitude toward ambush marketing was not significant ($b = -0.10$, $SE = 0.33$, $p = 0.76$).

To facilitate the interpretation, the simple slopes of attitude toward ambush marketing in each of the four conditions are reported: humorous counterad: $b = -0.14$, $SE = 0.22$, $p = 0.52$; name and shame counterad: $b = -0.47$, $SE = 0.23$, $p < 0.05$; educational counterad: $b = -0.79$, $SE = 0.24$, $p = 0.001$; and leveraging ad: $b = -0.24$, $SE = 0.25$, $p = 0.33$. The results thus support

the assumptions: the negative slope that is present in both the name and shame and the consumer education condition disappears not only in the humorous counterad condition but also in the leveraging-ad condition. Figure 3 displays the ratings of the appropriateness of the sponsor's counterambush marketing strategy as perceived by the subjects in the four experimental groups, depending on the level of attitude toward ambush marketing (using nonmean-centered scores of attitude toward ambush marketing across the range of values actually observed in the sample). A floodlight analysis showed that, at a level of 2.91 and higher (4.43 and higher) in attitude toward ambush marketing, that is, at the mean (1.57 SDs above the mean), the simple main effect of the countercommunication strategy was significant when comparing the humorous counterad condition with the name and shame (educational counterad) condition.

To find out whether perceived tactical appropriateness of the sponsor's counterstrategy mediates the effects of the different counterstrategies on attitude toward the ad (depending on attitude toward ambush marketing), a moderated mediation analysis was conducted. The analysis models perceived tactical appropriateness of the sponsor's counterstrategy as a function of counterstrategy (using three dummy variables as described earlier), mean-centered attitude toward ambush marketing, and the interactions of attitude toward ambush marketing and the three dummy variables. Attitude toward the ad depends on the same seven variables plus perceived tactical appropriateness of the sponsor's counterstrategy.

The regression results for perceived tactical appropriateness of the sponsor's counterstrategy are the same as those reported in Table 1. For attitude toward the ad (model $R^2 = 0.42$), the direct effect of perceived tactical appropriateness of the sponsor's counterstrategy was positive ($b = 0.68$, $SE = 0.10$, $p < 0.001$). The direct effects of the name and shame counterad condition (dummy 1; $b = -1.53$, $SE = 0.33$, $p < 0.001$), educational counterad condition (dummy 2; $b = -1.32$, $SE = 0.34$, $p < 0.001$), and leveraging-ad condition (dummy 3; $b = -0.95$, $SE = 0.34$, $p = 0.006$) were negative, but all interactions (dummy 1 $\times$ attitude toward ambush marketing $b = 0.17$, $SE = 0.36$, $p = 0.64$; dummy 2 $\times$ attitude toward ambush marketing $b = 0.10$, $SE = 0.37$, $p = 0.79$; dummy 3 $\times$ attitude toward ambush marketing $b = 0.42$, $SE = 0.37$, $p = 0.29$) were nonsignificant. Attitude toward ambush marketing was unrelated with attitude toward the ad ($b = -0.22$, $SE = 0.25$, $p = 0.37$). Unlike in Studies 1 and 2, Study 3 found no indication for moderated mediation effects of the counterambushing strategy on attitude toward the ad via perceived tactical appropriateness (despite the significant interaction effect of consumer education [dummy 2] and attitude toward ambush marketing on the mediator), depending on the level of consumer attitude toward ambush marketing. However, consistent with Studies 1 and 2, the results showed that the humorous counterad was positively related to attitude toward the ad, as opposed to

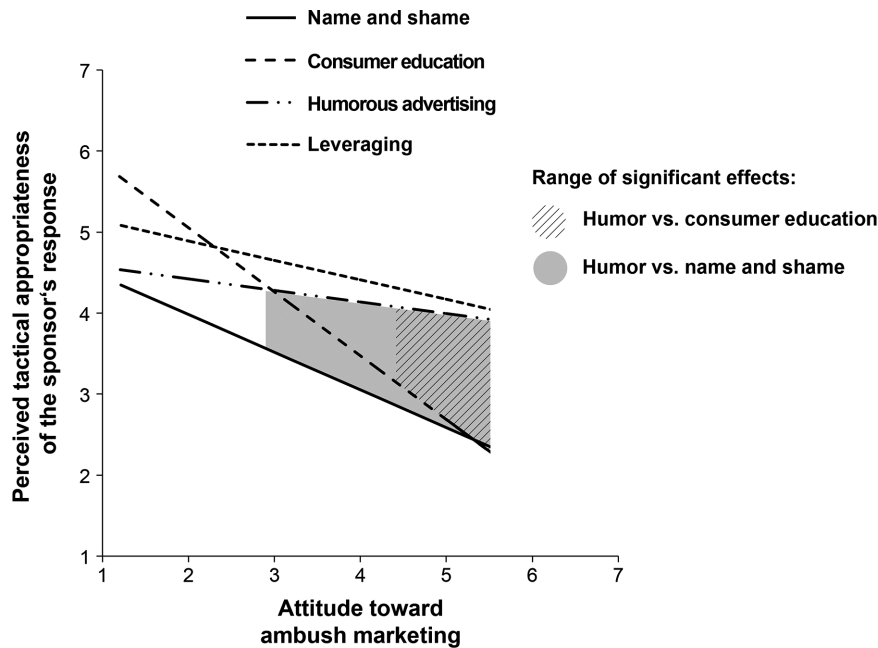


Figure 3. The relationship between recipients' attitudes toward ambush marketing and perceived tactical appropriateness of the sponsor's counterstrategy, depending on the experimental condition in Study 3 (humorous advertising vs. name and shame vs. consumer education vs. sponsorship leveraging).

both the name and shame counterad condition and the educational counterad condition. The humorous counterad also increased attitude toward the ad, compared with the leveraging ad. What is more, the negative relationship between consumer attitude toward ambush marketing and perceived appropriateness of the ad was present in both the name and shame and the consumer education conditions (like in Studies 1 and 2) but disappeared in both the humorous advertising and the sponsorship leveraging condition.

GENERAL DISCUSSION

The purpose of this research was to consider the effects of different types of ambushing countercommunications (employed by sponsors) on consumer attitudes toward sponsor ads at different levels of attitudes toward the general practice of ambush marketing. An understanding of how counterambushing communications affect the sponsor is critical because an important goal of any sponsorship message, including countermessages against an ambushing attack, is to strengthen the sponsor brand. Three studies showed how different types of countermessages and consumers' general attitudes toward ambush marketing influence their evaluations of the sponsor's advertising tactic and reactions to the countermessage itself. In this regard, the present research is a response to calls to investigate whether and how sponsors should respond to ambush marketing attempts via countercommunications (Humphreys et al., 2010).

Specifically, the three studies revealed that using humor in counterambushing ads results in higher perceptions that the advertising tactic is appropriate than both naming and shaming the ambusher and educational counterads. This increase in perceived tactical appropriateness mediated positive effects of humorous counterads on consumer attitudes toward the ad. Consumers' general attitudes toward ambush marketing are a boundary condition of how counterads influence consumer attitudes toward the ads. The positive direct and indirect effects of humorous counterads only occurred when consumers hold positive opinions (but not when they hold negative opinions) about the practice of ambush marketing. This research further showed that humorous counterads evoke similar levels of perceived tactical appropriateness as a common sponsorship leveraging ad that makes no direct or indirect reference to the ambusher. Also, humorous counterads exert a direct positive effect on attitude toward the ad, compared to the other two types of counterads and compared to a sponsorship leveraging ad.

Research Implications

Considering the ineffectiveness of the existing countermeasures in preventing ambush marketing, sponsors have two main options when they face an ambushing attack: to countercommunicate or to ignore the ambusher. Thus, research needs to address the question of whether or not countercommunications should be used at all and, if so, which type of countermessage is most beneficial for the sponsor. Past research into consumer

processing of event sponsorship messages in the presence of ambushing activities has almost exclusively focused on brand memory and brand-event associations as relevant outcome variables (e.g., Cornwell & Humphreys, 2013; Wolfsteiner, Grohs, & Wagner, 2015). Previous studies that looked at communications strategies to fight ambush marketing assessed how such messages influence memory links between the ambushing brand and the sponsorship property (Humphreys et al., 2010) or how they affect attitudes toward the ambusher (Mazodier et al., 2012). However, these studies considered ambush-marketing disclosure that originated from a third party (i.e., the media), and the studies did not look at recipients' evaluations of the countermessage. Thus, since the extant literature provides only limited answers to the question of whether or not and, if so, how sponsors should countercommunicate an ambushing attempt, the present research set out to advance the understanding of these issues.

While previous literature has discussed both the name and shame approach and consumer education as types of countercommunications (Burton & Chadwick, 2009; McKelvey & Grady, 2008), only the name and shame approach has been subject to empirical inquiry (Mazodier et al., 2012). This research provides empirical evidence that a humorous countermessage is a more beneficial approach for sponsors, compared to both of these previously discussed strategies. In particular, humorous counterads increase attitudes toward the ad, both directly and indirectly, through higher perceptions of tactical appropriateness. These results are in line with research into comparative advertising, suggesting that consumer responses to a negative and one-sided claim about a competitor are ambivalent at best (Jain & Posavac, 2004). This research shows that these findings also apply to counterambushing communications, where the comparison with the competitor does not relate to specific product characteristics but is more indirect and relates to abstract brand characteristics, such as legitimacy and integrity.

The findings indicate that the advantages of using humor in shaping perceptions of tactical appropriateness (and ad attitude, in turn) depend on consumers' preexisting attitudes toward the practice of ambush marketing, a variable that has been neglected in previous research on counterambushing communications (Mazodier et al., 2012). A denouncement of the ambusher can be in harmony or disharmony with consumers' general opinions about ambushing practices, and hence, influence perceptions of the appropriateness of a sponsor's counterad. An important feature of humor in counterads is that it acts as a buffer against perceptions of tactical inappropriateness when consumers think positively about ambush marketing. By contrast, consumers seem to accept a nonhumorous derogation of the ambusher, whether it is expressed directly (naming and shaming) or indirectly (consumer education), when this derogation is in harmony with their opinion about ambush marketing (i.e., when they hold negative opinions about ambushing).

The results of Study 3 reveal that the buffering effect of humorous counterads in the case of positive attitudes toward ambush marketing is even strong enough to produce the same level of perceived tactical appropriateness as common sponsorship leveraging ads. Thus, consumers in favor of ambush marketing evaluate an ad that derogates the ambusher as equally fair and ethical as a leveraging ad when the derogation happens humorously. This finding is important, as it indicates that humorous countercommunications can be a serious alternative to sponsorship leveraging when consumers hold positive opinions about ambushing or ambushers, which may often be the case, considering the creativity and wit of many ambushing activities (Cornwell et al., 2005).

On a broader level, the findings add to the literature, examining the moderating conditions that determine the relative effectiveness of comparative versus non-comparative advertising. The results of previous studies indicate that comparative ads evoke lower source believability and attitude toward the ad (Grewal et al., 1997). This research shows that humorous ad content can mitigate such unfavorable effects of comparative ads. The humorous counterambushing ads were evaluated most positively, compared with any other ad (i.e., both other types of countercommunications and sponsorship leveraging) considered in the studies. This was true for all studies (i.e., across sport and brand contexts and with different humorous content). This finding is in line with previous research showing that—due to its positive affect-inducing quality—humor is effective in increasing consumer liking of ads (Eisend, 2009). It is the first study, however, to provide evidence for these effects in a context where brands make references to other brands in their ads.

Managerial Implications

Sponsors employ countercommunications when they feel that the ambusher is getting some reward that it does not deserve by associating with an event, and that their own company should do something against that. The broadest managerial recommendation is that sponsors should consider the use of humorous content when they employ countercommunications in response to an ambushing attempt. Although the aggressive approach of fighting back the ambusher may seem intuitively reasonable, the gentler character of humorous derogation produces more favorable consumer responses to the sponsor's message. However, since any situation involving an ambushing and countercommunications attempt is variable and complex, several situational conditions need to be taken into account before any final recommendations can be made. To get a better understanding of the complexity of countercommunications, this research considered consumer attitudes toward ambush marketing as a boundary condition. The findings regarding this variable have implications for sponsorship managers, with respect to designing counterads for different situations and target groups.

The selection of an appropriate counterstrategy is particularly important when consumers hold positive attitudes toward the practice of ambush marketing. In this case, a humorous counterad produces the highest perceptions of tactical appropriateness, which translate into more positive attitudes toward the ad. Thus, sponsors should find creative and humorous ways to denounce the ambusher and refrain from using the name and shame approach and educational counterads when consumers are in favor of the ambusher and its activities. As Study 3 showed, humorous counterads are perceived as equally appropriate of an advertising tactic as sponsorship leveraging ads and produce even more positive attitudes toward the ad. Thus, sponsors might prefer the use of humorous counterads over leveraging ads when consumers think positively about ambush marketing.

However, in situations where consumers hold negative attitudes toward the practice of ambush marketing, there are no differences in perceived appropriateness of the advertising tactic between the different types of counterads, and the indirect effect of this variable on attitude toward the ad is nonsignificant (Studies 1 and 2). Only the results of Study 2 indicate that educational counterads may outperform both the humorous counterads and the name and shame approach at very low levels of attitude toward ambush marketing. In this study, the recipients perceived the educational counterads as significantly more appropriate than the other two strategies. In Study 3, however, this advantage of the educational counterads did not occur. Thus, the three types of counterads examined in this research produce similar consumer responses relating to the advertising tactic and the ads in situations where consumers reject the practice of ambush marketing. It can be expected that these situations occur when the sponsorship is regarded as a more social and less commercial activity, or when consumers are strongly attached to the sponsorship property and its sponsors (as is often the case in team sport settings).

Limitations and Future Research

This research is the first to examine consumer evaluations of counterambushing communications and, therefore, extends previous literature that looked at how countermessages affect evaluations of the ambusher. Future research will have to study the exact mechanisms that lead to inappropriateness perceptions of countermessages. It would be interesting to disentangle the role of affective and cognitive processes in the effects of different types of counterads. For example, the positive and direct effect of humorous counterads on attitude toward the ad that occurred in the studies indicates that other mediating variables than perceived tactical appropriateness should be included to fully explain how humorous content shapes consumer responses to countermessages. The immediate affective response to the ad is likely to be an important underlying mechanism that complements appropriateness perceptions.

Due to the complexity and variability of any situation involving an ambushing attempt and countercommunications, further studies should also identify and assess other boundary conditions that moderate the relative effectiveness of different types of countermessages. Potential boundary conditions relate to the sponsor and the ambushing brand (e.g., attitude, trust), sponsorship property (e.g., attachment, identification), message of the ambusher (e.g., awareness, perceived creativity, or humorousness), countermessage (e.g., awareness, perceived level of self-interest), and interplay of both messages (e.g., temporal distance between exposure to ambushing attempt and exposure to countermessage). For example, the effects of the counterads likely depend on consumers' awareness of the ambushing attempt, a variable that was held constant in the forced exposure design of the studies, which ensured high ad visibility and elaborate processing of the message content.

CONCLUSIONS

Sponsors pay for an association with a sponsored property and are thus in search for the right strategies to deal with ambushers that do not possess official sponsorship rights but still associate with the property or related aspects. This study indicates that the use of humor is a good strategy to increase the perceived appropriateness of countercommunications when consumers hold positive opinions about ambush marketing. Sponsors can directly and indirectly (via perceived tactical appropriateness) increase consumer attitudes toward the counterad by using humorous content. Thus, sponsors should consider the use of humor when raising their voice against ambushers and be careful with using both naming and shaming and educational counterads in these situations.

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APPENDIX 1

Advertisements used in Study 1:



Slogan:

“FOR MORE SAFETY”

Figure A1. Ambushing ad. [Color figure can be viewed at wileyonlinelibrary.com]

Counter-ads	
Name and shame	Humorous
<u>Headline:</u> “DON’T GET DECEIVED BY DUREX!” <u>White box:</u> “Durex is not an official sponsor but a marketing cheater.”	<u>Headline:</u> The expression “MIT ERLAUBNIS EINLOCHEN” in the headline is a pun. “MIT ERLAUBNIS” means “WITH PERMISSION.” The term “EINLOCHEN” has two meanings in this context: 1) the golf setting brings to mind the meaning “putting the ball in the hole” and 2) the term is also an informal synonym for sexual intercourse. Since the ambusher and the sponsor are condom manufacturers, this second meaning of the term comes to mind. <u>White box:</u> “As the official sponsor, BILLY BOY guarantees: More safety for players and the tournament!”

Figure A2.

Advertisements used in Study 2:



Slogan:

“PACK YOURSELF WITH ENERGY FOR THE BEST DIVE.”

Figure A3. Ambushing ad. [Color figure can be viewed at wileyonlinelibrary.com]

Name and shame	Counter-ads Humorous	Educational
<u>Headline:</u> “DON’T GET DECEIVED BY NRG!” <u>Subheadline:</u> “NRG is not an official sponsor but a marketing cheater.”	<u>Headline:</u> “DON’T BE A LOSER, BOOST YOURSELF!” [The German word “FLASCHE” used for “LOSER” has two meanings: 1) loser and 2) bottle. The ambushing ad illustrates that the ambusher NRG sells its sports drink in bottles, whereas the sponsor’s sports drink is sold in cans. Thus, the headline of the humorous counter-ad alludes to the ambushing brand in a humorous way by saying “DON’T BE A ‘FLASCHE’” (= loser or bottle).]	<u>Headline:</u> “DON’T GET DECEIVED BY AMBUSH MARKETING FRAUD!” <u>Subheadline:</u> “So-called ambush marketing activities describe unauthorized free-riding of brands that attempt to benefit from an event without possessing official sponsorship rights. This unethical behavior threatens the financial stability of the FINA Diving Grand Prix.”

Figure A4.

Advertisements used in Study 3:

In Study 3, the same ads as in Study 1 were used for the ambusher and the name and shame counterad condition, as well as the humorous counterad condition.

Additional counter-ads

Educational



Headline:
“SAY NO TO AMBUSH MARKETING!”

White box:
“Ambush marketing = free-riding! This unethical behavior threatens the financial stability of the YGA tournament.”

Sponsorship leveraging



Headline:
“YGA CHAMPIONSHIP – SPONSORED BY BILLY BOY”

White box:
“BILLY BOY and YGA – shared responsibility for the YGA tournament.”

Figure A5.

APPENDIX 2

Table A1. Measures Used in the Studies.

	Item means (and SDs), [scale reliabilities]		
	Study 1	Study 2	Study 3
Model variables			
Perceived tactical appropriateness of the sponsor's counterambush marketing communications (Barone & Jewell, 2012) ^a	[$\alpha = 0.73$]	[$\alpha = 0.78$]	[$\alpha = 0.83$]
Unfair/fair	4.43 (1.56)	4.48 (1.77)	4.29 (1.42)
Dishonest/honest	4.86 (1.67)	4.70 (1.80)	4.53 (1.62)
Unreasonable/reasonable	3.78 (1.92)	4.19 (1.87)	3.83 (1.79)
Unethical/ethical	4.25 (1.32)	4.20 (1.44)	4.02 (1.22)
Attitude toward the ad (adjectives taken from MacKenzie, Lutz, & Belch, 1986)	[$\alpha = 0.95$]	[$\alpha = 0.93$]	[$\alpha = 0.95$]
Unlikeable/likeable	3.40 (2.07)	3.60 (1.95)	3.44 (1.84)
Unfavorable/favorable	3.35 (1.80)	3.42 (1.79)	3.34 (1.65)
Bad/good	3.62 (1.91)	3.62 (1.85)	3.61 (1.77)
Attitude toward ambush marketing (Koenigstorfer & Groeppel-Klein, 2012; one item was added to have an equal number of positively and negatively formulated items) ^b	[$\alpha = 0.70$]	[$\alpha = 0.76$]	[$\alpha = 0.62$]
It is exaggerated how well the official sponsors are protected in the context of the event	3.54 (1.42)	3.33 (1.42)	3.40 (1.27)
Every brand should be allowed to advertise with the event, regardless of who owns the sponsorship rights	2.84 (1.57)	2.68 (1.53)	2.83 (1.48)
Protection of the official sponsors is highly necessary to finance the event ^c	2.58 (1.33)	2.61 (1.25)	2.66 (1.17)

(Continued)

Table A1. Continued.

	Item means (and SDs), [scale reliabilities]		
	Study 1	Study 2	Study 3
I think it is right that official sponsors are well protected against free-riders ^c	2.81 (1.39)	2.81 (1.45)	2.82 (1.38)
Manipulation check variables			
Perceived humorousness (McGraw et al., 2012)	[$r = 0.92$]	[$r = 0.93$]	[$r = 0.96$]
Not funny/funny	3.29 (1.99)	3.04 (2.02)	3.33 (2.04)
Not amusing/amusing	3.35 (2.10)	3.04 (2.02)	3.40 (2.00)
Perceived level of derogation of the ambusher (Jain, 1993)	[$r = 0.52$]	[$r = 0.52$]	[$r = 0.50$]
[Sponsor]'s ad criticized [ambusher]	5.53 (1.55)	5.61 (1.36)	5.06 (1.80)
[Sponsor]'s ad derogated [ambusher]	4.93 (1.51)	4.29 (1.53)	4.33 (1.67)
Perception of the ad content as educational (new measure)	–	[$r = 0.66$]	^d
[Sponsor]'s ad informs about the negative consequences of ambush marketing	–	3.95 (1.61)	–
[Sponsor]'s ad explains how ambush marketing threatens the event	–	3.55 (1.73)	–

Notes: ^aThe following introductory sentence was given: "In my opinion, [sponsor]'s approach to countering the ambushing attempt is:"

^bAttitude toward ambush marketing was unaffected by the experimental manipulation in Study 1 ($t(105) = 1.10, p = 0.28$), Study 2 ($F(2,159) = 2.17, p = 0.12$), and Study 3 ($F(3,122) = 1.20, p = 0.31$).

^cReverse-coded items.

^dDue to a mistake, the measure was not assessed in Study 3. Semantic differentials were assessed on a 7-point scale (from 1 to 7). All other items were anchored at 1 (fully disagree) and 7 (fully agree).

APPENDIX 3

Manipulation Check

Study 1: Perceived humorousness of the advertisement was higher for the humorous counterad ($M = 4.59$) compared to the name and shame counterad ($M = 2.02$; $t(105) = 8.38, p < 0.001$). Perceived derogation of the ambusher was higher in the name and shame condition ($M = 6.02$) than in the humorous advertising condition ($M = 4.52$; $t(105) = 7.00, p < 0.001$).

Study 2: Perceived humorousness of the advertisement was higher for the humorous counterad ($M = 5.02$) compared to both the name and shame counterad ($M = 2.36$) and the educational counterad ($M = 1.88$; $F(2,159) = 75.23, p < 0.001, \Delta M = 2.66, SE = 0.28, p < 0.001$ and $\Delta M = 3.14, SE = 0.28, p < 0.001$, respectively). Perceived derogation of the ambusher was higher in the name and shame condition ($M = 5.62$) than in the humor condition ($M = 5.06$) and the education condition ($M = 4.96$; $F(2,159) = 5.35, p = 0.006, \Delta M = 0.56, SE = 0.22, p = 0.03$ and $\Delta M = 0.66, SE = 0.22, p = 0.009$, respectively). Perceptions of the ad content as educational was higher for the educational counterad ($M = 4.94$) compared to both the humorous ($M = 3.11$) and the name and shame counterads ($M = 3.19$; $F(2,159) = 36.03, p < 0.001, \Delta M = 1.83, SE = 0.24, p < 0.001$ and $\Delta M = 1.75, SE = 0.24, p < 0.001$, respectively). Therefore, the manipulation was deemed successful.

Study 3: The manipulation check showed that perceived humorousness of the advertisement was higher for the humorous counterad ($M = 5.11$) than for the name and shame counterad ($M = 2.68$), the educational counterad ($M = 2.38$), and the leveraging ad ($M = 3.28$; $F(3,122) = 16.20, p < 0.001, \Delta M = 2.43, SE = 0.42, p < 0.001, \Delta M = 2.73, SE = 0.44, p < 0.001$, and $\Delta M = 1.83, SE = 0.44, p < 0.001$, respectively). Perceived derogation of the ambusher was higher in the name and shame condition ($M = 5.06$) than in the humorous counterad condition ($M = 3.50$), the educational counterad condition ($M = 4.17$), and the leveraging-ad condition ($M = 3.22$; $F(3,122) = 14.26, p < 0.001, \Delta M = 1.56, SE = 0.30, p < 0.001, \Delta M = 0.89, SE = 0.31, p = 0.03$, and $\Delta M = 1.84, SE = 0.31, p < 0.001$, respectively). Therefore, the manipulation was deemed successful. Note that the difference in perceived derogation between the educational counterad and the leveraging ad was also significant ($\Delta M = 0.95, SE = 0.32, p = 0.02$).